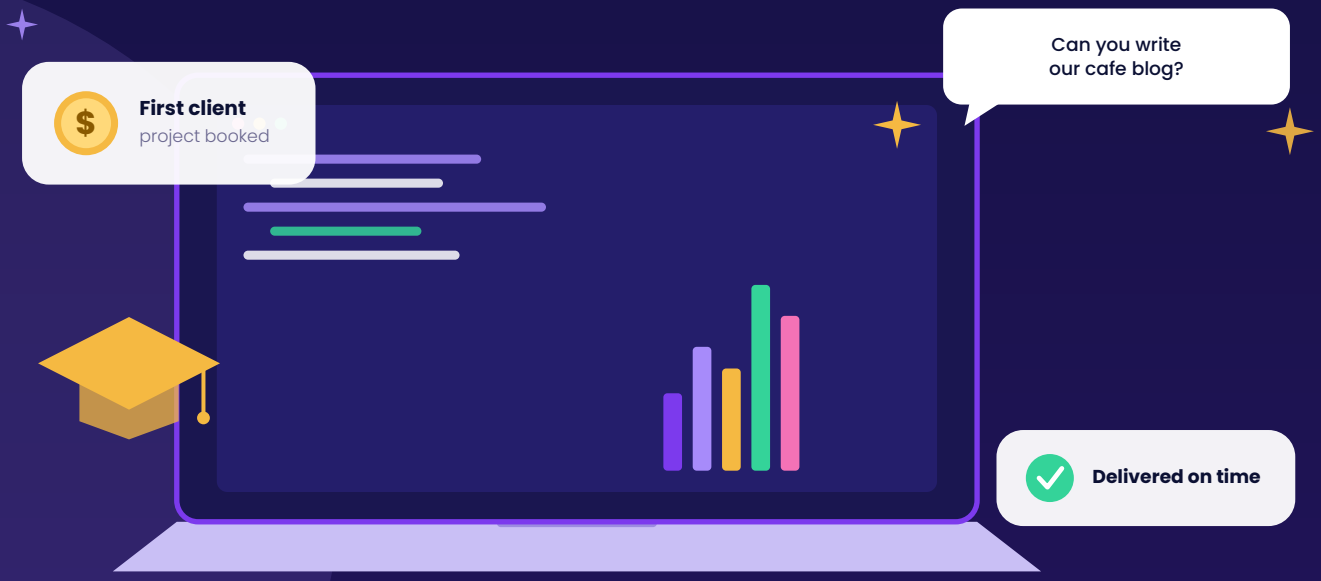
READNOVAHUB

FREE AI TOOLS • REAL SKILLS

The Student AI Side Hustle Playbook

Turn free AI tools into freelance skills, digital services and your first online income.



WRITTEN BY READNOVAHUB

2026 Edition | International English

10	50	10	30
practical chapters	ready-to-use prompts	outreach templates	day action plan

A beginner-friendly guide with realistic expectations. No income guarantees.

COPYRIGHT AND EDUCATIONAL DISCLAIMER

© ReadNovaHub. All rights reserved. This book is for educational purposes only. It does not guarantee income, clients or any particular result. Earnings depend on your skills, effort, local market demand and many other factors. AI tools change quickly, so check each tool's current terms, pricing, privacy policy and free-plan limits before relying on it. Nothing here is legal, tax or financial advice. Check the rules for freelancing in your country, your school and your age group (many platforms require users to be 18 or older). Names of businesses used in examples are fictional.

Contents

Contents 2

Welcome to ReadNovaHub 3

Part I: Understand the opportunity 4

Chapter 1. The Student's Guide to AI-Powered Side Hustles 4

Chapter 2. Your Free AI Business Toolkit 5

Part II: Turn skills into services 7

Chapter 3. AI-Assisted Content Writing Services 7

Chapter 4. Social Media Content and Canva Design 8

Chapter 5. Resume, Presentation and Document Services 10

Chapter 6. Research and Data Assistance 11

Part III: Build a real freelance business 13

Chapter 7. Build a Portfolio That Wins Trust 13

Chapter 8. Find Your First Potential Clients 14

Chapter 9. Pricing, Communication and Delivery 16

Part IV: Take action and grow 17

Chapter 10. Your 30-Day Student AI Side-Hustle Plan 17

Practical Bonus Toolkit 19

50 Useful AI Prompts for Student Freelancers 19

10 Client Outreach and Follow-Up Templates 21

Checklists, Worksheets and Tracker 22

Personal 30-Day Action Tracker 23

Glossary of Essential Terms 23

Resource Directory 24

WELCOME

Welcome to ReadNovaHub

Learn it. Build it. Earn from it, honestly.



Most "make money with AI" content sells a fantasy: press a button, wait, get paid. This playbook takes the opposite view. AI is a powerful assistant, but clients do not pay for AI. They pay for **useful, accurate, well-presented work delivered reliably by someone they trust.**

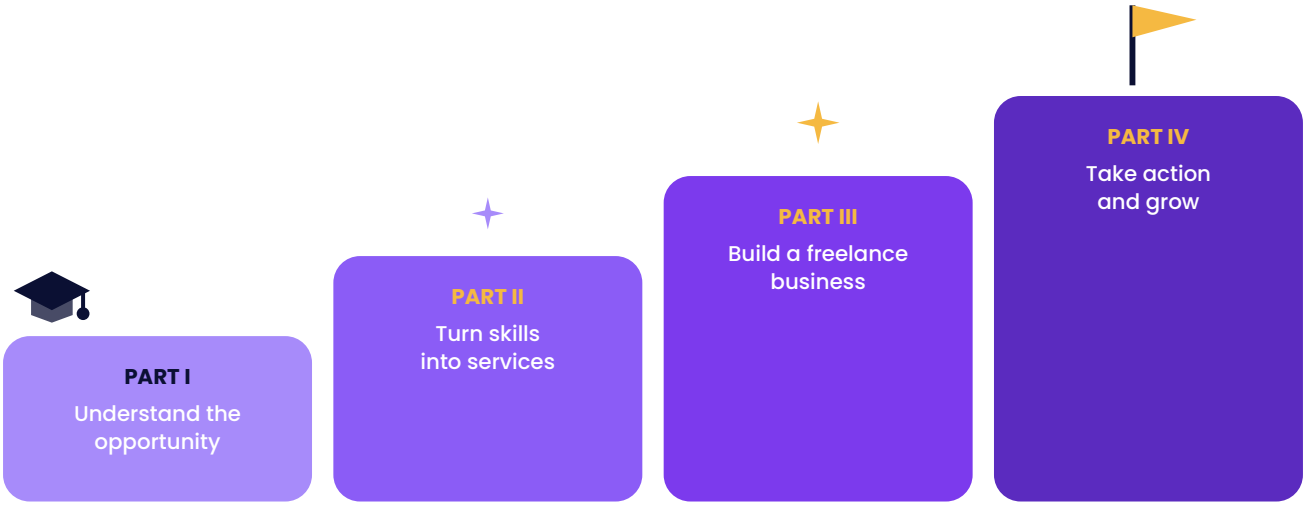
As a student you already have an edge. Every week you write, research, summarise, design slides and organise information. This book shows you how to turn those everyday skills into small professional services, and how to use free AI tools to work faster and better without cutting corners.

By the end you will have chosen one service, built portfolio samples, contacted potential clients and worked through a 30-day plan aimed at your first paid or trial project.

How to use this playbook

- **Read in order the first time.** Each part builds on the last: understand the opportunity, learn the services, build the business, then act.
- **Do the action tasks.** Reading alone will not earn you anything. Each chapter ends with a short task.
- **Choose one service, not five.** Chapters 3 to 6 describe four services. Read them all, then pick the one that fits you best.
- **Keep a Hustle Folder.** One cloud folder with subfolders: Samples, Clients, Templates, Finances.
- **Use the toolkit at the back.** Prompts, templates, checklists and worksheets you can copy and adapt.

Your student side-hustle roadmap



PART I

Understand the opportunity

What an AI side hustle really is, and the free toolkit to run one.

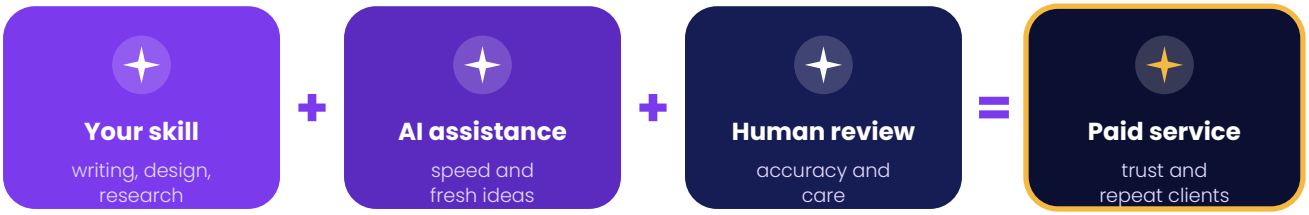
CHAPTER 1

The Student's Guide to AI-Powered Side Hustles

Understand what is realistic before you spend a single hour.

What an AI side hustle really is

An AI side hustle is a small service or product you offer **using AI tools to speed up parts of the work, while you provide the judgment, quality control and client communication.** Remove any ingredient and it falls apart. Without your skill you cannot judge whether the output is good. Without AI you may work more slowly than competitors. Without human review you risk errors that damage your reputation.



Why students have an opportunity

- **You learn tools quickly.** New apps do not scare you.
- **Your costs are low.** Free tools and a laptop or phone are enough to begin.
- **Your time is flexible.** Small projects fit around classes.
- **Local businesses need help.** Many shops, tutors, creators and clubs lack time for content, documents and organisation.
- **You can start small.** A low-priced first project that earns a good review is worth more than waiting for a perfect offer.

Three routes: freelancing, service businesses, digital products

Route	What it is	Example	Best for beginners?
Freelancing	One-off tasks for clients, on platforms or directly	A blog post, a set of social graphics	Yes: fast feedback
Service business	Defined packages for repeat clients	Monthly content for a local cafe	Yes: after 1-3 projects
Digital products	Make once, sell many times	Resume or Canva templates	Slower: needs quality and marketing

This playbook focuses on **services**, because they earn you feedback, testimonials and income while you learn.

What AI can and cannot do

AI is good at	AI is poor at
Drafting first versions quickly	Knowing whether facts are true
Brainstorming ideas and angles	Understanding a client's unspoken needs
Rewording and summarising text	Matching a brand's real personality without guidance
Formatting, outlining, organising	Taking responsibility for mistakes
Suggesting formulas and structures	Keeping confidential data safe on its own

> **GOLDEN RULE**
> AI can sound confident while being wrong. It can invent statistics, sources and quotes. **Everything you deliver must be checked by you.**

Choose skills over shortcuts

Shortcut thinking asks, "Which AI trick makes the most money?" Skill thinking asks, "Which valuable skill can I get good at, and how can AI help me deliver it better?" Clients notice generic work. Writing clearly, designing neatly, researching carefully and communicating professionally will outlast any single tool.

ACTION TASK

Write down (1) three things you do well as a student, (2) three types of people or businesses who might need those skills, (3) how many hours per week you can honestly commit.

CHAPTER 2

Your Free AI Business Toolkit

A small set of tools you know well beats a long list you barely use.

You do not need a big budget. You need a handful of tools, a tidy folder system and clear rules for using them responsibly.

AI **AI assistant** drafts, ideas, edits	Cv **Canva** graphics and slides	Sh **Spreadsheet** lists, data, charts
Cl **Cloud storage** files and sharing	Pr **Proofreader** second-pass checks	Tk **Tasks and notes** deadlines, client info

Choosing the right AI assistant

Use one general-purpose AI assistant for drafting, brainstorming, editing and explaining. Before committing, check three things:

- **Free-plan limits:** messages per day, file uploads, feature access.
- **Privacy settings:** does it use your chats to train models, and can you opt out?
- **Quality for your service:** run the same task in two tools and compare.

Pick one primary assistant and learn it deeply. Constant switching wastes time.

Canva and visual content creation

Canva's free plan gives you templates, text tools, basic brand colours and exports for social posts, presentations and simple documents. Learn brand colours, consistent fonts, grids and spacing. Treat templates as starting points, never finished products, and export PNG for images or PDF for documents. Always check licence terms for templates, photos and fonts before commercial use.

Spreadsheets, files and collaboration

- **Spreadsheets** handle lists, trackers and basic charts. AI can write formulas and explain errors, but you must verify the numbers.
- **Cloud storage** with clear names and dates. Use version names like *ClientName_Project_v1*, *v2*, *Final*.
- **Shared links** with view or comment access, not edit access, unless the client needs it.
- **Backups** of every piece of client work.

Free-plan limits and responsible use

Rule	Why it matters
Never paste confidential client data into a tool without permission	You may breach trust or privacy law
Be honest about how you work if asked	Some clients want human-only work; trust is your main asset
Check copyright on images, fonts and text	Using unlicensed material can get you and your client in trouble
Read platform and school rules on AI use	Policies differ and can change
Plan for limits	Free plans can change or run out mid-project; keep spare time in deadlines

EXAMPLE LINKS TO EXPLORE	
AI assistant: Claude - General-purpose assistant with a free tier	claude.ai
AI assistant: Gemini - Works with Google Docs and Drive	gemini.google.com
Canva - Free design tool for posts, slides, documents	www.canva.com
Google Drive, Docs and Sheets - Free storage and office tools	drive.google.com
Hemingway Editor - Free readability checker for your drafts	hemingwayapp.com

Links are examples, not endorsements. Websites change, so check each link and read its terms before use.

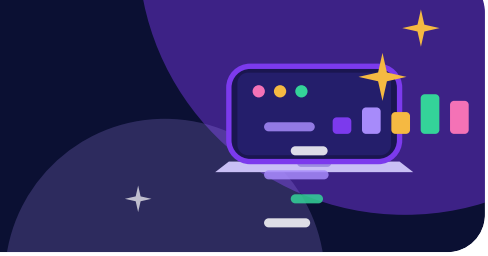
ACTION TASK

Set up your Hustle Folder. Choose one AI assistant, one design tool, one spreadsheet app and one cloud storage service. Run a small test in each (for example, ask the assistant to explain a course topic in plain language) and note what you had to correct.

PART II

Turn skills into services

Four beginner-friendly services. Read them all, then choose one.



CHAPTER 3

AI-Assisted Content Writing Services

Blog posts, product descriptions, emails and editing: written by you, sped up by AI.

Written content is one of the easiest services to start because every business needs words: websites, shops, newsletters and social pages. Many owners are busy and want a reliable person who can turn rough notes into clear copy.

What you can offer

Service	Deliverable	How AI helps	What you must do
Blog and web content	400-800 word posts, page copy	Outlines, first drafts, headline ideas	Fact-check, add the client's real details and voice
Product descriptions	Sets of 50-120 word descriptions	Variations from a feature list	Keep claims accurate; avoid copied text
Email and newsletters	Welcome emails, monthly newsletters	Subject lines and structure	Match tone; check links and offers
Editing and proofreading	Corrected, clearer documents	Spots errors and clumsy sentences	Preserve meaning; explain major changes

The delivery workflow

1 Client brief → 2 Outline → 3 AI first draft → 4 Rewrite and fact-check → 5 Proofread → 6 Deliver

A complete client-work example

Scenario. Maple & Bean (a fictional local cafe) asks for a 400-word blog post titled "Why We Roast Our Beans Locally." The owner sends rough notes: roasting happens twice a week, beans come from two named farms, and a loyalty card gives the tenth coffee free.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

You are a copywriter for a friendly neighbourhood cafe. Write a 400-word blog post titled "Why We Roast Our Beans Locally" for regular customers and students. Use only these facts: [paste owner's notes]. Tone: warm, simple, no hype. Include a short intro, three subheadings and a call to action about the loyalty card. Do not invent statistics or quotes.

What the student did next. The first draft claimed the coffee was "the freshest in the country," which the owner never said, so it was removed. Two sentences sounded generic, so they were rewritten with the owner's own detail about Tuesday and Friday roasting. The headings were tightened, a spell-check and read-aloud pass followed, and the owner approved it after one small revision. Sample opening:

"Twice a week, before most of the street is awake, our roaster starts up and the whole shop smells like toasted caramel. That smell is the reason we roast locally."

QUALITY-CONTROL CHECKLIST

- Every fact comes from the client or a source you checked
- No copied text (run a plagiarism check)
- Tone matches the brand
- Names, prices and links are correct
- Spelling and grammar checked twice
- File named and saved properly

EXAMPLE LINKS TO EXPLORE	
Hemingway Editor - Spot long, hard-to-read sentences	hemingwayapp.com
Grammarly - Grammar and clarity suggestions (free plan)	www.grammarly.com
HubSpot Academy - Free courses on content and email marketing	academy.hubspot.com
Google Docs - Share drafts with comment access for client feedback	docs.google.com

Links are examples, not endorsements. Websites change, so check each link and read its terms before use.

ACTION TASK

Choose a small business you know (real or imagined). Write one 300-word sample post using the workflow above. Keep notes on what you changed from the AI draft; they become portfolio material in Chapter 7.

CHAPTER 4

Social Media Content and Canva Design

Plan, write and design a month of posts for a small business.

Small businesses know they should post regularly, but few have the time. A **content package** solves this: a set number of captions and designed graphics delivered on a schedule.

A simple package

- 12 posts per month (8 images, 2 carousels, 2 text-based quote or tip posts)
- Captions with hashtag suggestions
- A one-page content calendar
- Brand colours and fonts applied consistently
- One round of revisions

Captions, calendars and post ideas

A good calendar mixes **education** (tips), **trust** (behind the scenes, stories), **engagement** (polls) and **promotion** (offers). Aim for mostly useful posts, with selling kept to a smaller share.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
W1	Tip		Story		Promo	Poll	
W2	Quote		Tip		Reel	Behind	
W3	Tip		Poll		Promo	Story	
W4	Reel		Tip		Quote	Promo	

EXAMPLE PROMPT

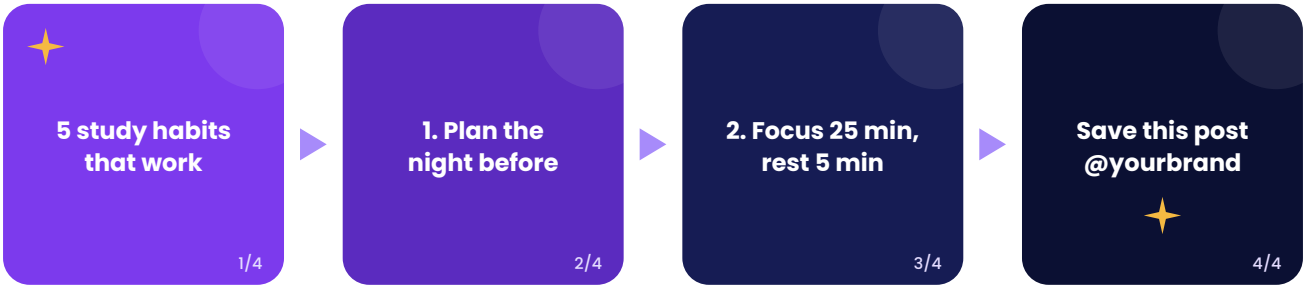
Create a 4-week content calendar for [business] on [platform], 4 posts per week. For each post give: day, post type (tip, story, poll, promo, behind the scenes), topic and a one-line caption idea. Audience: [describe]. Tone: [describe].

Designing simple branded graphics

Open Canva, set up a brand kit (two main colours, one accent, two fonts) and design one template per post type. Keep text large, margins generous and one idea per graphic. Consistency makes a page look professional far more than fancy effects.

Creating carousel posts

Carousels work well for tips because people swipe through. Use a bold hook on slide 1, one idea per slide, and a clear action on the last slide.



Build a sample package

Invent a fictional business, such as *Green Leaf Tutoring*, and create a calendar, six captions and six matching graphics. Label the work clearly as a **sample**. Export a PDF preview for your portfolio.

AVOID COPYRIGHT AND DESIGN MISTAKES

- Do not use trending music, logos or characters you do not own
- Check that every font, photo and element is free for commercial use (Canva marks premium items)
- Get permission before showing identifiable people
- Never copy another brand's design
- Keep text readable: strong contrast, large type

EXAMPLE LINKS TO EXPLORE	
Canva Design School - Free lessons on layout, colour and branding	www.canva.com/designschool
Pexels - Free photos; read the licence for each use	www.pexels.com
Unsplash - Free photos; check licence terms	unsplash.com
Google Fonts - Free fonts that are safe to pair	fonts.google.com
Meta Business Suite - Schedule posts for Facebook and Instagram	business.facebook.com

Links are examples, not endorsements. Websites change, so check each link and read its terms before use.

ACTION TASK

Build the sample package: one calendar, six captions, six graphics in one brand style. Save it as *Sample_GreenLeaf_Social_v1.pdf* in your Samples folder.

CHAPTER 5

Resume, Presentation and Document Services

Help people present themselves and their ideas clearly. Handle their information with care.

Students, job seekers, clubs and small teams all need polished documents. This service rewards **attention to detail** and **trustworthiness**, because you handle personal information.

What you can offer

- **Resume formatting and improvement:** clean layout, consistent style, stronger wording based on the client's real experience.
- **Cover letters and bios:** structured drafts the client personalises and approves.
- **Presentation design:** turning rough notes into clear slides with one message each.
- **Business documents and reports:** tidy formatting, summaries, templates.



A safe resume workflow

1. Collect facts from client
2. Remove personal details
3. AI wording suggestions
4. Check every fact
5. Format and export
6. Client approval

EXAMPLE PROMPT

Rewrite these resume bullet points using strong action verbs and a clear result where I have provided one. Do not add any facts, numbers, tools or employers that are not in my text: [paste bullets, with names replaced by placeholders].

Presentation design

Keep one idea per slide, a headline that states the takeaway, no more than about 30 words on a slide, and consistent colours. For a 10-minute talk, 6 to 8 slides is plenty. Ask AI for an outline and speaker notes, then design the slides yourself so they feel intentional.

ACCURACY, PRIVACY AND APPROVAL

- Never invent jobs, degrees, skills or numbers
- Replace names, phone numbers and addresses with placeholders before using any AI tool, then add them back
- Store client files privately and delete them when the project and agreed storage period end
- Send a final version for written approval before you consider the job complete

EXAMPLE LINKS TO EXPLORE	
Europass CV editor - Free CV templates and guidance	europass.europa.eu
Canva Resumes - Resume templates to adapt (check licence)	www.canva.com/resumes
Google Slides - Free presentation tool with easy sharing	slides.google.com
LinkedIn - Study real profiles for structure ideas	www.linkedin.com

Links are examples, not endorsements. Websites change, so check each link and read its terms before use.

ACTION TASK

Create a before-and-after sample using a fictional person. Show a messy resume and a clean version side by side. Write three sentences explaining what you improved and why.

CHAPTER 6

Research and Data Assistance

Turn messy information into clear, trustworthy summaries.

Small teams, student societies and local businesses often have notes, survey answers and spreadsheets they never have time to organise. Your job is to make them **clear and correct**.

What you can offer

- **Research summaries:** short, sourced briefings on a topic.
- **Spreadsheet cleaning and formatting:** tidy, consistent data.
- **Basic data visualisation:** a clear chart and a sentence about what it shows.
- **Survey summaries:** main findings and limitations.

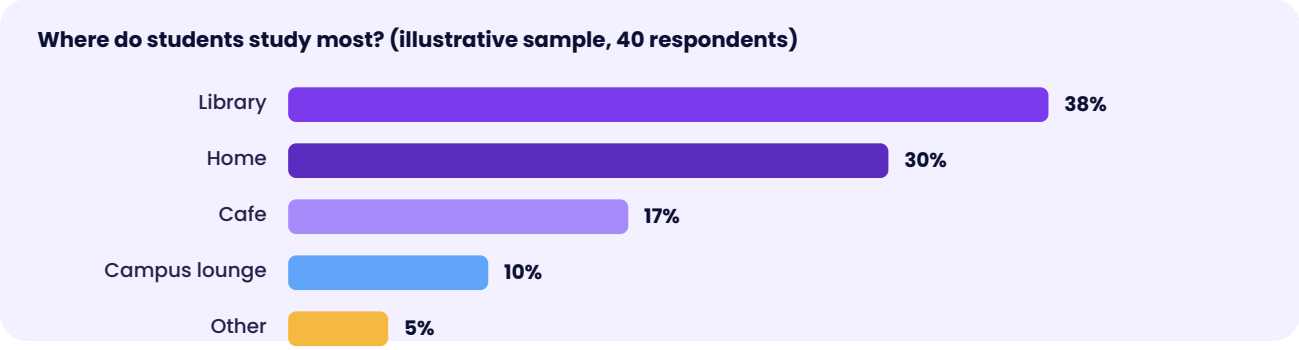
Cleaning a spreadsheet

Raw entry	Problem	Cleaned
john SMITH	Extra spaces, odd capitals	John Smith
12/03/24 and 2024-03-12	Mixed date formats	2024-03-12
Yes / yes / Y	Inconsistent answers	Yes
Duplicate row	Repeated respondent	Removed (after backup)

Always **copy the original sheet first**. Useful formulas to learn: `=TRIM(A2)` removes extra spaces, `=PROPER(A2)` fixes capitals, and `=COUNTIF(B:B,"Yes")/COUNTA(B:B)` gives the share of "Yes" answers. Ask AI to explain a formula, then test it on a few rows by hand.

Basic data visualisation

Pick the simplest chart that answers the question: bars to compare categories, lines for change over time. Label the axes, title the chart with the finding, and state the sample size.



Fact-checking and source verification

- Find **two independent, reliable sources** for every important claim.
- Prefer primary sources (official statistics, original studies) over summaries.
- Check dates: old data can be misleading.
- Ask AI to list claims that need checking, then verify them yourself. Never cite a source you have not opened.

HANDLE SENSITIVE INFORMATION SAFELY

Survey answers, health details, grades and contact lists are sensitive. Remove names and identifiers before using AI, collect only what you need, and follow the client's instructions on storage and deletion. If the data is too sensitive, say no.

EXAMPLE LINKS TO EXPLORE	
Google Sheets - Free spreadsheets with built-in charts	sheets.google.com
Google Forms - Free surveys that feed into Sheets	forms.google.com
Google Scholar - Find academic papers to verify claims	scholar.google.com
Our World in Data - Free charts and sources on global topics	ourworldindata.org
World Bank Open Data - Free datasets for research practice	data.worldbank.org

Links are examples, not endorsements. Websites change, so check each link and read its terms before use.

ACTION TASK

Make a sample: take a small invented survey of 20 answers, clean it, create one chart and write a five-sentence summary with two limitations (for example, the small sample).

PART III

Build a real freelance business

Portfolio, clients, pricing and delivery.

CHAPTER 7

Build a Portfolio That Wins Trust

A portfolio proves you can do the work before anyone has hired you.

Select your first service

Score each service from 1 to 5 on the four questions below. Choose the highest total and commit to it for 30 days.

Service	I enjoy it	I am already decent	Local demand	Time I have
Content writing				
Social media and Canva				
Resumes and documents				
Research and data				

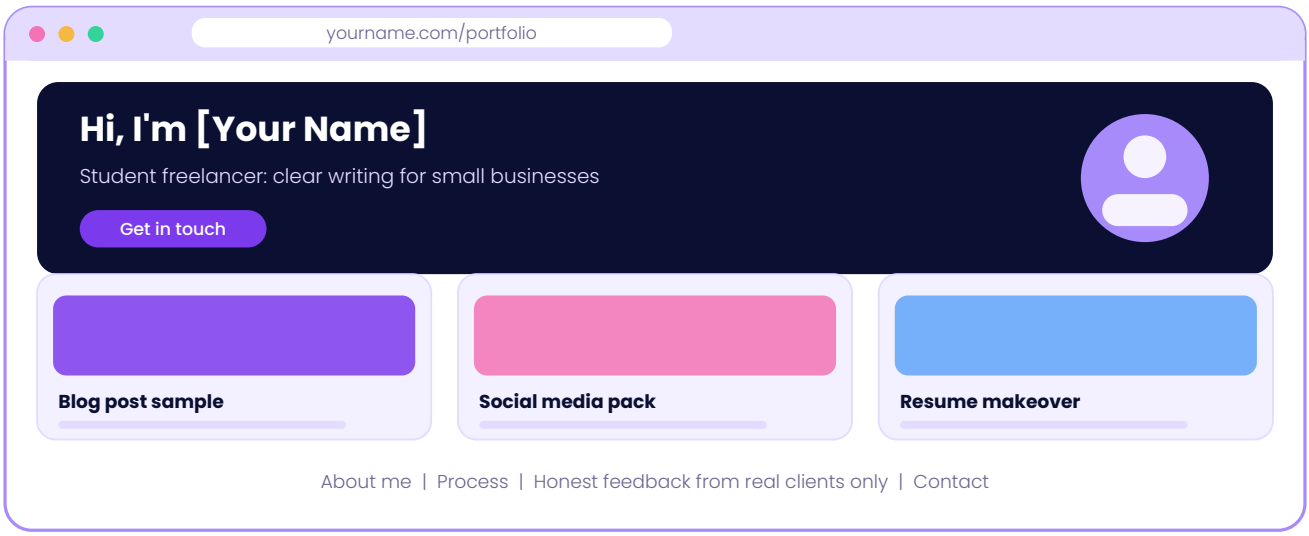
Create samples without clients

You do not need clients to build proof. Make **three strong samples**:

- For a fictional business (clearly labelled as a sample).
- For a real club, charity or family business, with permission.
- A before-and-after improvement of a messy document or page.

Write strong project descriptions

For each sample, write five short parts: **Challenge** (what the client needed), **What I did**, **Tools** (including AI, honestly), **Result** (only what is true) and **What I learned**.



Build a simple portfolio

One clean page is enough. Include a short introduction, your service, three samples, how you work, and a way to contact you. Free options include a Canva website, a Google Site, a Notion page or a Behance profile.

SHOW PROCESS AND RESULTS HONESTLY
Never fake testimonials, client names or numbers. Mark samples as samples. If AI helped, say how you used it and what you checked. Honesty is not a weakness; it is what makes a beginner trustworthy.

EXAMPLE LINKS TO EXPLORE	
Canva Websites - Build a one-page site for free	www.canva.com/websites
Google Sites - Free website builder	sites.google.com
Behance - Portfolio platform for design work	www.behance.net
Notion - Make a clean public page	www.notion.so

Links are examples, not endorsements. Websites change, so check each link and read its terms before use.

ACTION TASK
Finish three samples and publish one portfolio page. Ask one friend or teacher to read it and tell you what is unclear.

CHAPTER 8

Find Your First Potential Clients

Be specific, be polite, and send enough messages to learn what works.

Platforms and direct outreach

Freelance platforms bring buyers to you but also bring competition. Direct outreach to small businesses takes courage but lets you stand out. Many beginners use both.

Route	Pros	Cons
Freelance platforms	Buyers are already looking; payment protection	Crowded; fees; reviews matter; age limits often apply
Direct outreach	Less competition; builds relationships	Many will not reply; you must find leads
Referrals	Warm trust; best conversion	Needs a few finished projects first

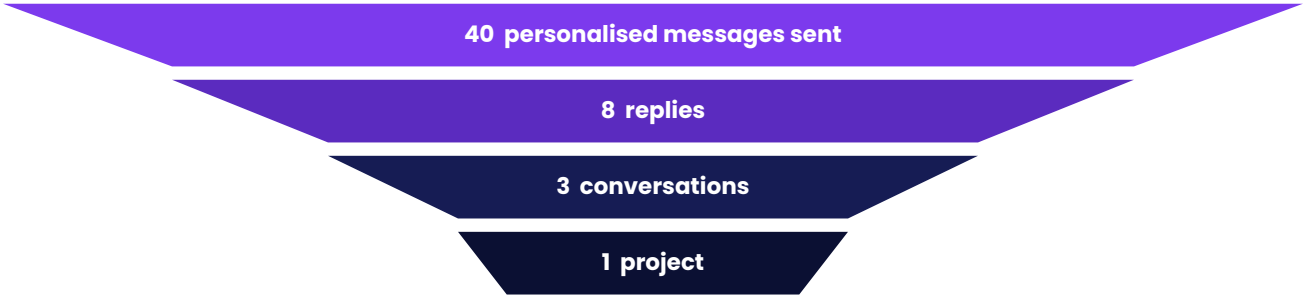
Finding suitable small businesses

Look for local businesses with an active but inconsistent online presence: cafes, tutors, gyms, salons, florists, clubs. Note one specific thing you could improve, such as a missing newsletter or an outdated page.

Writing a personalised proposal

1. Personal opener
2. Problem you noticed
3. Your offer
4. Proof from sample
5. Easy next step

SAMPLE FIRST MESSAGE
Hello [Name], I enjoyed your recent post about [specific detail]. I noticed [specific problem, e.g. your newsletter has not gone out since June]. I'm a student who writes simple, friendly emails for local businesses. Here is a sample I made: [link]. Would you like a short plan for your next newsletter? Thanks, [Your name]



Illustrative example only. Real response rates vary widely.

Networking and referrals

Tell teachers, friends, family and student societies exactly what you offer. "I help local businesses write clear newsletters" is easier to pass on than "I do AI stuff."

SPOT SCAMS AND SUSPICIOUS CLIENTS

- Asks you to pay a fee, buy equipment or cash a cheque first
- Moves quickly to private chat and refuses platform payment
- Pay is far too high for the task
- Wants your ID, bank login or passwords early
- Vague job with a big "test" project. If unsure, stop, tell a trusted adult and report it to the platform.

EXAMPLE LINKS TO EXPLORE	
Upwork - Freelance marketplace (check age rules)	www.upwork.com
Fiverr - Create service listings (check age rules)	www.fiverr.com
Freelancer - Bid on projects	www.freelancer.com
LinkedIn - Connect with local business owners	www.linkedin.com
FTC consumer advice - Learn how common job scams work	consumer.ftc.gov

Links are examples, not endorsements. Websites change, so check each link and read its terms before use.

ACTION TASK

Make a list of 20 potential clients with one specific observation for each. Send five personalised messages this week.

CHAPTER 9

Pricing, Communication and Delivery

Clear packages and calm communication make you look professional from day one.

Create beginner-friendly packages

Three packages remove confusion: a small **Starter**, a balanced **Standard** and a larger **Premium**. Each should state exactly what is included.

Starter	Standard (MOST POPULAR)	Premium
Your price	Your price	Your price
1 deliverable	3 deliverables	Monthly package
1 revision round	2 revision rounds	2 revision rounds
Delivery in 3 days	Delivery in 5 days	Priority replies
	Short style guide	Progress summary

Set prices and define scope

Start with a simple formula: **hours you expect × your target hourly rate + 20% for messages and revisions**. For example, if you expect 2.5 hours and your target is 10 currency units per hour: 2.5 × 10 = 25, plus 20% = 30. This is an illustration only; rates differ widely by country, service and experience. Look at what similar beginners charge, then adjust as your portfolio grows.

Ask the right client questions

- Who is this for, and what should they do after reading or seeing it?
- What tone and examples do you like or dislike?
- What facts, links or files must be included?
- What is the deadline, and who approves the final version?
- How many revision rounds are included?

Manage revisions and deadlines

State the number of revisions in writing. Promise deadlines with a buffer and warn the client early if something changes. When a client asks for extra work, offer a friendly paid add-on rather than a silent yes.

SCOPE-CHANGE MESSAGE

Thanks for the extra idea! It sits outside the agreed package, but I can add it for [price] and [extra time]. Would you like me to include it, or finish the current scope first?

Deliver professionally and handle feedback

Send one clear message with the files, a short list of what is included, how to request revisions and a polite payment note. Read feedback as information, not criticism: fix issues quickly, ask for a short testimonial with permission to share it, and suggest a next step such as a monthly package.

GET PAID SAFELY

Use platform payment protection, or send a simple invoice with a clear due date. A small deposit for larger jobs is common. Keep records of income and check your local rules on reporting and tax.

EXAMPLE LINKS TO EXPLORE	
Wave - Free invoicing tool	www.waveapps.com
Trello - Track projects on a simple board	trello.com
Calendly - Let clients book a short call	calendly.com

Links are examples, not endorsements. Websites change, so check each link and read its terms before use.

ACTION TASK

Create your three packages, write your scope and revision rules in plain language, and save them as a one-page PDF to attach to proposals.

PART IV

Take action and grow

A realistic 30-day plan to your first project.

CHAPTER 10

Your 30-Day Student AI Side-Hustle Plan

Small, specific actions every week will beat big plans you never start.



Week 1: Learn and choose a service

- Set up your Hustle Folder and tools (Chapter 2)
- Read Chapters 3 to 6 and score the services
- Choose one service and one type of client
- Write your one-sentence offer

Week 2: Create portfolio samples

- Finish three samples with honest project descriptions
- Publish a one-page portfolio
- Draft your three packages and prices
- Ask someone for feedback and improve

Week 3: Reach out to potential clients

- Build a list of 20 leads with one observation each
- Send five personalised messages (more if you can)
- Create profiles on one or two platforms (check age rules)
- Follow up politely after five days

Week 4: Improve, deliver and review

- Reply fast and run discovery calls with your question list
- Deliver your first paid or trial project with the checklist
- Ask for feedback and a testimonial
- Review what worked and plan month two

Weekly progress tracker

Week	Hours worked	Messages sent	Replies	Samples done	What I learned
1					
2					
3					
4					

Next steps after your first project

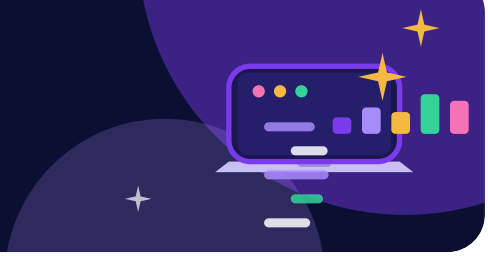
Ask what the client enjoyed, request a testimonial, update your portfolio and offer a follow-up package. Keep improving one skill at a time, raise prices gradually as your work and reviews improve, and keep every promise you make.

> **REALISTIC EXPECTATIONS**
> Some students land a first project within weeks; for others it takes longer. Both are normal. Progress means more messages sent, better samples and clearer communication, not a promised income.

PART V

Practical bonus toolkit

Prompts, templates, checklists, worksheets and a resource directory.



50 USEFUL AI PROMPTS

Replace the [brackets] with real details. Always review and fact-check the output, and remove private information before pasting anything.

Writing

1	Write a 500-word blog post for [business type] about [topic] for [audience]. Tone: [tone]. Include a headline, subheadings and a call to action.
2	Give me 10 headline options for a blog post about [topic], each under 70 characters.
3	Create an outline for a blog post on [topic] with an intro, four sections and a conclusion.
4	Write three product descriptions of about 80 words for [product], highlighting [features] for [customer].
5	Draft a welcome email for new subscribers of [business]. Friendly, under 150 words, one clear link.
6	Write five subject lines for a newsletter about [topic]. No spam words, no all caps.
7	Rewrite this paragraph in a clearer, friendlier tone without changing the facts: [text].
8	Proofread this text. List each error, then show the corrected version: [text].
9	Summarise this article in five bullet points for a busy business owner: [text].
10	Suggest five ways to make this web page more useful for first-time visitors: [text].

Social media and design

11	Create a 4-week content calendar for [business] on [platform], four posts per week, with post type and topic.
12	Write five Instagram captions for [business] about [topic], each under 40 words with three relevant hashtags.
13	Turn this blog post into a 5-slide carousel with a title and 15 words per slide: [text].
14	Suggest 10 post ideas that educate rather than only sell for [business type].
15	Write three 30-second video scripts for [business] showing [topic].
16	Create a five-bullet brand voice summary for [business] based on: [description].
17	Suggest a colour palette and font pairing for [business] suited to [audience], with hex codes.
18	Write 10 call-to-action lines for social posts about [goal].
19	Draft a polite, helpful reply to this customer comment: [comment].
20	Suggest five poll or question posts to engage [audience].

Resumes, slides and documents

21	Rewrite these resume bullets with action verbs. Do not add facts I did not give: [bullets].
22	Suggest a clear resume structure for a [role] candidate with [experience level].
23	Draft a three-sentence professional bio for [name], [role], using only: [facts].
24	Outline a cover letter for this job using only my real experience: [job] / [experience].
25	Turn these notes into a 6-slide outline with one key message per slide: [notes].
26	Write about 60 words of speaker notes for each slide in this outline: [outline].
27	Convert these meeting notes into a one-page summary with decisions and action items: [notes].
28	Create a simple report template for [purpose] with guidance under each heading.
29	Shorten this text by 30% while keeping the key points: [text].
30	List five things in this document a reader might find unclear: [text].

Research and data

31	Explain [topic] in plain language for a beginner, then list five key terms.
32	Create a research plan for [question]: what to search and which sources to trust.
33	Summarise the main arguments for and against [topic] in a balanced way. List what I should verify.
34	Suggest a Google Sheets formula to [task] in column [X].
35	Explain this spreadsheet error and how to fix it: [error and formula].
36	Suggest steps to clean this data: [describe columns and problems].
37	Which chart best shows [data] to [audience], and why?
38	Write eight clear survey questions to learn [goal], avoiding leading questions.
39	Summarise these anonymised survey results in five findings and two limitations: [data].
40	List the claims in this text that need a source check: [text].

Business and clients

41	Write a friendly proposal to [client] offering [service], under 150 words, mentioning [specific detail].
42	Draft seven questions to ask a new client before a [service] project.
43	Write a polite follow-up to a client who has not replied for five days.
44	Explain politely that an extra request is outside the agreed scope and offer a paid add-on.
45	Write a delivery message summarising what is included and how to request revisions.
46	Turn these notes into a portfolio case study: challenge, process, result, lesson: [notes].
47	Suggest three packages (starter, standard, premium) for [service] with clear limits.
48	Write a short message asking a happy client for a testimonial.
49	Help me write a polite decline for a project that is too big for me.
50	Review my 30-day plan and point out the weakest part: [plan].

10 OUTREACH TEMPLATES

Keep messages short, specific and kind. Personalise every one.

1. FIRST EMAIL TO A SMALL BUSINESS
Hello [Name], I'm a student who helps local businesses with [service]. I noticed [specific detail] and made a short sample to show how it could look: [link]. May I send a quick idea for your next [post/newsletter/page]? Thank you, [Your name]

2. DIRECT MESSAGE (INSTAGRAM OR LINKEDIN)
Hi [Name], I like what you do at [business]. I'm building my portfolio in [service] and noticed [specific detail]. Would it be okay if I shared a short idea? No pressure at all.

3. PLATFORM PROPOSAL
Hi [Name], I read your brief carefully. I would [do X] in [timeframe] and include [Y revision rounds]. Here is a similar sample: [link]. Could you tell me [one specific question] so I can match your tone?

4. FOLLOW-UP AFTER FIVE DAYS
Hi [Name], I'm following up on my earlier message in case it got buried. I'm happy to adjust the idea or answer any questions. Thank you for your time.

5. SECOND FOLLOW-UP
Hi [Name], I'll assume the timing isn't right, so I won't message again. If you ever need help with [service], my portfolio is here: [link]. Best wishes with [business].

6. THANK YOU AFTER A CALL
Thank you for speaking with me today. To confirm: you need [deliverable] by [date], with [number] revision rounds, for [price]. Please reply "agreed" and I will begin.

7. SMALL FREE SAMPLE (USE SPARINGLY)
I'd be glad to make one short sample, such as [one caption or one paragraph], so you can see my style before deciding. If you like it, here is my Starter package: [details].

8. REFERRAL REQUEST
Hi [Name], I'm starting a small [service] service for local businesses. If you know anyone who might need help with [specific task], I would be grateful for an introduction. Thank you!

9. TESTIMONIAL REQUEST
Thank you for working with me! If you're happy with the result, could you share two or three sentences about your experience? I'd love to include them on my portfolio, with your permission.

10. RE-ENGAGING A PAST CLIENT
Hi [Name], I hope [business] is going well. I enjoyed working on [project]. I have availability next month if you'd like [new idea]. Would you like a short plan?

CHECKLISTS AND WORKSHEETS

Freelance portfolio checklist

- One clear sentence about who I help and how
- Three samples, labelled honestly
- Each sample has challenge, process, tools, result
- Clear contact method
- No fake testimonials or numbers
- Proofread twice; links tested on phone and laptop

Sample service pricing worksheet

Package	What is included	Hours	Hourly target	+20% buffer	My price
Starter					
Standard					
Premium					

Client project brief

Question	Client's answer
Client and contact	
Goal of the project	
Audience	
Tone and examples they like	
Files and facts provided	
Deliverables and format	
Deadline and approver	
Revision rounds included	
Price and payment date	

Final quality-control checklist

- Facts and numbers verified from real sources
- No copied text or unlicensed images
- Names, dates, prices and links correct
- Tone matches the brief
- No private data left in the file
- Spelling and grammar checked twice
- File named clearly and opened on another device
- Delivery message includes revision instructions

PERSONAL 30-DAY ACTION TRACKER

Write one small action for each day, then tick it off.

Day	Action	Done	Day	Action	Done
1			16		
2			17		
3			18		
4			19		
5			20		
6			21		
7			22		
8			23		
9			24		
10			25		
11			26		
12			27		
13			28		
14			29		
15			30		

Glossary of essential freelance and AI terms

Brief
The client's written description of what they want.

Scope
Exactly what work is and is not included.

Scope creep
Extra requests added without changing price or deadline.

Deliverable
A finished item handed to the client.

Proposal
A short offer explaining how you will help.

Portfolio
A collection of your best work samples.

Testimonial
A client's written feedback shared with permission.

Retainer
A repeating monthly arrangement.

Deposit
Part payment made before work starts.

Revision round
One set of requested changes.

Prompt
The instruction you give an AI tool.

Hallucination
When AI states something false as if it were true.

Brand voice
The consistent personality of a brand's writing.

CTA
Call to action: what you want the reader to do next.

Niche
A focused group or topic you serve.

Lead
A potential client.

Turnaround time
How long delivery takes.

Invoice
A bill that requests payment.

RESOURCE DIRECTORY

Example links grouped by purpose. Tap or click any link in the digital version.

AI assistants	Claude (claude.ai) Gemini (gemini.google.com)
Design and visuals	Canva (www.canva.com) Canva Design School (www.canva.com/designschool) Google Fonts (fonts.google.com) Pexels (www.pexels.com) Unsplash (unsplash.com)
Writing and editing	Hemingway Editor (hemingwayapp.com) Grammarly (www.grammarly.com) Google Docs (docs.google.com)
Spreadsheets and research	Google Sheets (sheets.google.com) Google Forms (forms.google.com) Google Scholar (scholar.google.com) Our World in Data (ourworldindata.org) World Bank Open Data (data.worldbank.org)
Learning	HubSpot Academy (academy.hubspot.com) Europass (europass.europa.eu)
Portfolio	Google Sites (sites.google.com) Canva Websites (www.canva.com/websites) Behance (www.behance.net) Notion (www.notion.so)
Finding clients	Upwork (www.upwork.com) Fiverr (www.fiverr.com) Freelancer (www.freelancer.com) LinkedIn (www.linkedin.com)
Business tools and safety	Wave invoicing (www.waveapps.com) Trello (trello.com) Calendly (calendly.com) FTC consumer advice (consumer.ftc.gov)

Links are examples, not endorsements. Websites, prices and free-plan limits change, so confirm each link and read its terms before relying on it.

Start small.
Stay honest.
Keep showing up.

Your first client is not waiting for a perfect version of you.
They are waiting for someone who is useful, clear and reliable.